

Education Pathway Comparison (Model Column)

NAME _____ DATE _____ PERIOD _____

Column 1 is filled in for you as a model. Read it first. Then fill in Column 2 with an associate degree career and Column 3 with a bachelor's degree career.

Use the Hats & Ladders app for the career, the CompTIA Career Roadmap for the certification, and the BLS website for the salary. Rough numbers are fine.

FIELD	CAREER 1: CERTIFICATION ONLY	CAREER 2: ASSOCIATE DEGREE + CERT	CAREER 3: BACHELOR'S DEGREE
Career Name	Help Desk Technician		
Required Education	High school diploma plus the CompTIA A+ certification		
Time to Complete	2 to 6 months of study after high school		
Estimated Cost	About \$250 to \$500 in exam fees		
Median Salary (BLS)	About \$60,000 a year. DFW starting pay is closer to \$40,000 to \$50,000.		

Where to find each number

- **Required Education:** the education indicator on the Hats & Ladders Hat profile.
- **Time to Complete:** months for a certification, 2 years for an associate degree, 4 years for a bachelor's degree.
- **Estimated Cost:** certifications run about \$200 to \$1,000. An associate degree at a community college runs about \$5,000 to \$15,000. A bachelor's degree runs \$40,000 and up.
- **Median Salary:** the BLS Occupational Outlook Handbook page for that job.

Think About It

1. Which path takes the LEAST time? Which path takes the MOST? Use the numbers from your table.

2. If you wanted to start earning money as fast as possible, which path would you choose? Give one reason from your table.
